

able universities, it ended up adding to the corruption in the whole system. So much so that when CBI raided the Jaipur home of an NCTE deputy secretary recently, valuables worth crores of rupees were unearthed. He was also found to be running three B.Ed. colleges and one engineering college.

A senior MHRD official says the process of granting approval to teacher training colleges is completely out of sync with the demand for teachers in that state. So while colleges are being granted affiliation with questionable regularity in states such as Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra, other states such as Orissa, Sikkim and Meghalaya are languishing. Sikkim has just two B.Ed colleges and one elementary teacher training college, while Uttar Pradesh has 700 B.Ed colleges and 184 Basic Teacher Certificate (BTC) colleges—a comparison not explained by the difference in size alone.

The demand of elementary and primary school teachers is always greater than that for secondary and college teachers, yet there are more colleges offering secondary level courses. Add to that the multiplicity of degrees at all levels: as many as 7,567 courses have been granted recognition by NCTE, most of which are more or less the same. For example, a primary teacher could go for a Diploma in Education which is a two-year programme or for a BTC which is a one-year programme in some colleges and two-year in others or for a Bachelor's in Elementary Education which is a four-year programme. NCTE chairman Shardendu is unruffled by this duplication: "As long as the curriculum is the same, there is no problem with multiple names of courses."

The crux of the problem, says Ved Prakash, former chairman of NCTE and currently vice-chancellor of the National University of Educational Planning and Administration, is the overriding powers given to the regional committees stationed in Bangalore, Bhubaneswar, Jaipur and Bhopal. According to MHRD's Sathyam committee report, much has been happening with the connivance of regional directors and applicant colleges with many applications being processed out of

turn. Inspecting teams have often consisted of persons of questionable credibility and in some cases affiliation was granted even to non-existent colleges.

These allegations are now being individually probed by the Sathyam committee. The committee has already submitted a report, an ode to the ingenuity of NCTE officials in violating rules. The sum collected as application fee (NCTE receives almost 4,000 applications every year with each applicant paying Rs 40,000 which means a minimum earning of Rs 16 crore every year) is kept in a current account with no planning of expected income and expenditure or investment. No

offered so far. The simple reason why NCTE should be abolished, says R.P. Singh, former MHRD joint secretary and the president of the All India Association of Teacher Educators, is that it has distorted the definition and meaning of teacher education itself. The director of National Council of Education Research and Training (NCERT) Krishna Kumar advocates the bifurcation of the regulatory and academic aspect of teacher education. "Wherever there is licensing, there are problems," he adds suggesting that the universities could discharge the duty of regulation of colleges whereas the academic aspect—laying down guide-



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MISPLACED PRIORITY: NCTE has ignored the training of primary teachers

chronology has been followed in granting permission—while some colleges have to wait for years for inspection teams to visit them, others are processed in days and some are even granted affiliation without inspection teams having visited them.

Says Anita Rampal, senior faculty member, Department of Education, Delhi University, "NCTE officials were going around giving approval to all sorts of colleges whereas for our B.Ed programme we had to wait for months." Not surprisingly, Mata Sundri College, Delhi had to wait for four years before an inspection team was sent to it despite an approval from the Delhi University.

The Government is considering repealing the NCTE Act but no concrete alternative model to replace it has been

lines for teacher education—could be done by NCERT in collaboration with the universities. Nursery and elementary education too should be brought into the net, ending the licence raj as well as the duplication, explains Kumar.

As of now, it is obligatory for a university to grant affiliation to a teacher training college if NCTE recognises it, even though the university finds it unsatisfactory. There have been incidents when universities have been forced to go to court against NCTE affiliations. In Uttar Pradesh alone there have been 389 such complaints. Whether the NCTE Act is repealed or amended, the task of restoring quality to teacher training colleges is a mammoth one. And the Government's decision could well influence the entire education system—for better or worse.